

Pollo Asado

Achiote-citrus (red) & green herb-jalapeno · cubed thigh · griddle chop-and-sear

YIELD	ACTIVE	MARINATE	GRIDDLE (IR)
1.5 kg · 6–8	~15 min	2–24 hr	450–500°F

TWO MARINADES

Per 450 g (1 lb) thigh — ratios scale linearly

ACHIOTE-CITRUS · RED

Achiote paste El Yucateco brick	30 g
Orange juice fresh	30 g
Lime juice fresh	15 g
Garlic minced	10 g
Olive oil	15 g
Salt · pepper · oregano	4 · 1 · 1 g

GREEN · HERB-JALAPEÑO

Jalapeno seeded, minced	30 g
Cilantro packed, at finish	15 g
Lime juice fresh	30 g
Garlic minced	10 g
Olive oil	30 g
Salt · cumin · oregano	4 · 2 · 1 g

Break up the achiote brick in the citrus first — whisk it into the orange + lime juice before adding oil, or it stays gritty and dyes-streaky. **Cilantro goes in at the finish only** — cooked in the marinade it turns muddy and flat; raw at the end it stays bright. Marinade window is **2 hr minimum, 24 hr max** — past 24 hr the acid breaks down the meat to mush.

TEMPERATURE TARGETS

IR-confirm the surface — don't eyeball it

Griddle surface (IR)	450–500°F	Chicken internal	165–175°F
Char coverage	15–20%	Final texture	crisp edge, juicy

Cook & Finish

METHOD

Active ~15 min — serve immediately

- 1 **Cube:** cut thighs into **1–1.5" (2.5–4 cm)** pieces, uniform for even cooking.
- 2 **Mix:** whisk the marinade smooth — **break up the achiote in the citrus first** — until the color is uniform.
- 3 **Marinate:** coat every piece, refrigerate **2–24 hr** (overnight is the sweet spot). **Never past 24 hr.**
- 4 **Temper:** pull the chicken **20 min** before cooking. Heat griddle / cast iron until screaming — **IR 450–500°F**.
- 5 **Sear:** single layer, **do not crowd**, 2–3 min/side for char. Let the pan recover between batches — crowding steams, no char.
- 6 **Chop:** all chicken back on the surface, chop with two spatulas, let it sit **30–60 sec**, toss. Builds crispy edges.
- 7 **Finish:** fresh lime squeeze (both profiles); **fresh cilantro on the green only**. Pull at **165–175°F**, serve now.

Chop-and-sear is the same move as shawarma — cubing then chopping on the hot surface multiplies the seared edge without overcooking the interior, so you get crispy edges *and* juicy centers. The achiote turns bitter if the paste is old or scorched: use fresh paste and **medium-high, not nuclear**, once the chicken is down.

TROUBLESHOOTING

PROBLEM	CAUSE	FIX
Bland inside	Under-marinated or cubes too large	Full 24 hr; cut smaller (1")
No char	Pan too cool or overcrowded	Smaller batches; recover to 450–500°F
Dry meat	Overcooked or low oil in marinade	Pull at 165–175°F; keep the oil ratio
Mushy texture	Over-marinated — acid too long	Max 24 hr; do not exceed
Achiote bitter	Old paste or burnt during sear	Fresh paste; medium-high, not screaming
Green tastes flat	Cooked the cilantro	Add cilantro at the finish only, never in the pan

NOTES

Scaling · serving

Scaling: the per-450 g ratios scale linearly — 1.5 kg is 3.3× a single pound. **Serving:** tacos, burritos, rice bowls; pairs with pickled onion, crema, and salsa. **Same family as the shawarma** — oil-carried marinade, hot iron, chop finish.